

Interview Script: Popularity Heat Map

Opening

"Hi, I'm [name] (SAY YOUR NAME). I'm working on a class project at Columbia, exploring how people find new places to eat, hang out, and explore. I'm not selling anything. I just want to understand your experience. Would you mind chatting for about 25 minutes?"

"Great. By the way, it's OK to be brutally honest with me. You can't hurt my feelings. That's how we improve our ideas."

Part 2: Who are they?

1. What do you do right now? (Student, job, field)
2. How often do you go out to try a new restaurant, café, or spot, and where do you usually hear about them?

Part 3: Problem exploration

3. What's the hardest part about figuring out where to go when you have free time?
4. Can you tell me about the last time you saw a place on TikTok or Instagram and wanted to go? Did you end up going? (**Follow up with "Why?" until you reach the root cause. Also ask: "How often does that happen?" and "How did that make you feel?"**)
5. What happens to the posts you save or send to friends with "we need to go here"? When was the last time you went back to them?

Part 4: Current solutions

6. What, if anything, have you done to keep track of places you want to try or to figure out what's good nearby?
7. What don't you love about the apps or methods you use now, like Google Maps, Yelp, or your saved folders?
8. Have you ever spent money trying to solve this, like on an app, a subscription, a reservation service, or a paid guide? How much?

Part 5: Solution signal

Pitch: "So based on what you've told me, we're actually exploring building a map that shows what's popular around you right now. The idea is that it pulls in places people are talking about on social media and shows them as a live heat map, so you can see what's worth going to near you in the moment."

9. Have you tried anything like this before? If yes, why did you stop using it?
10. What's your initial reaction? Would this solve the problem we've been talking about, and what concerns do you have with it?

Part 6: Wrap-up

11. If you could wave a magic wand and change one thing about how you find and go to new places, what would it be?
12. Is there anything about this I should have asked but didn't?

Closing commitments (ask these every time, since they are your strongest signal)

- "Do you know 1-2 other people who deal with this? Would you connect me?"
- "Would you be open to a 10-minute follow-up in a couple weeks?"
- "If you could pre-purchase this right now for \$10, would you?"

Interview Script: Crowd-Avoider (Inverse Heat Map)

Opening

"Hi, I'm [name]. I'm working on a class project at Columbia, exploring how people deal with crowds when they go out or travel. I'm not selling anything. I just want to understand your experience. Would you mind chatting for about 25 minutes?"

"Great. By the way, it's OK to be brutally honest with me. You can't hurt my feelings. That's how we improve our ideas."

Part 2: Who are they?

1. What do you do right now? (Student, job, field)
2. When you go out or travel, what kinds of places do you usually go to, and how do you pick them?

Part 3: Problem exploration

3. What's the hardest part about going to popular places, either in your own city or when you travel?
4. Can you tell me about the last time you showed up somewhere and it was way more crowded than you expected? What did you do? (*Follow up with "Why was that frustrating?" until you reach the root cause. Also ask: "How often does that happen?" and "How did that make you feel?"*)
5. Have you ever skipped going somewhere, or left early, because you were worried about crowds or lines? What happened?

Part 4: Current solutions

6. What, if anything, do you do now to avoid crowds or long lines? (Going early, checking Google's "popular times," asking friends, picking less popular spots)
7. What don't you love about those methods?

8. Have you ever spent money to avoid crowds or waits, like skip-the-line tickets, reservations, rideshares to beat a rush, or paying more for an off-peak option? How much?

Part 5: Solution signal

Pitch: "So based on what you've told me, we're actually exploring building a map that shows places worth visiting that aren't overcrowded. The idea is that it tracks what's blowing up on social media and shows you calmer alternatives nearby, along with the best times to go to places you already want to visit."

9. Have you tried anything like this before? If yes, why did you stop using it?
10. What's your initial reaction? Would this solve the problem we've been talking about, and what concerns do you have with it?

Part 6: Wrap-up

11. If you could wave a magic wand and change one thing about dealing with crowds when you go out or travel, what would it be?
12. Is there anything about this I should have asked but didn't?